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Amazon denies report it's shutting down Wondery podcast studio



Amazon is denying that it's shutting down Wondery, the podcast studio it [acquired in late 2020](#), after [Bloomberg reported](#) on Monday that the company was closing the studio and cutting 110 jobs.

Amazon told TechCrunch that Wondery will continue to develop creator-led podcasts under the Wondery brand within a new team. What's changing is that the company is separating the teams that oversee Wondery's narrative podcast efforts from those developing its creator-led shows.

Wondery is closing its narrative podcast studio, which includes podcasts like *Dr. Death* and *American Scandal*, with Audible.

“The podcast landscape has evolved significantly in the past few years, particularly with the rise of video-forward, creator-led content,” Amazon said in an emailed statement.

“These changes reflect that evolution and will streamline how Wondery integrates further into Amazon. By making these changes, we can better support creators in monetizing their content across multiple channels, help them expand their brand IP, and simplify the process for advertisers while making content more accessible to audiences wherever they prefer to consume it. This evolution builds on Wondery’s early success with video-forward shows and positions us to better serve creators, customers, and advertisers.”

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Despite securing big names in the business, the company is now shifting its strategy in an effort to better compete with rivals like Spotify and YouTube as the podcasting industry embraces video formats.

Update: The article was updated to reflect that Amazon denied reports of Wondery shutting down.

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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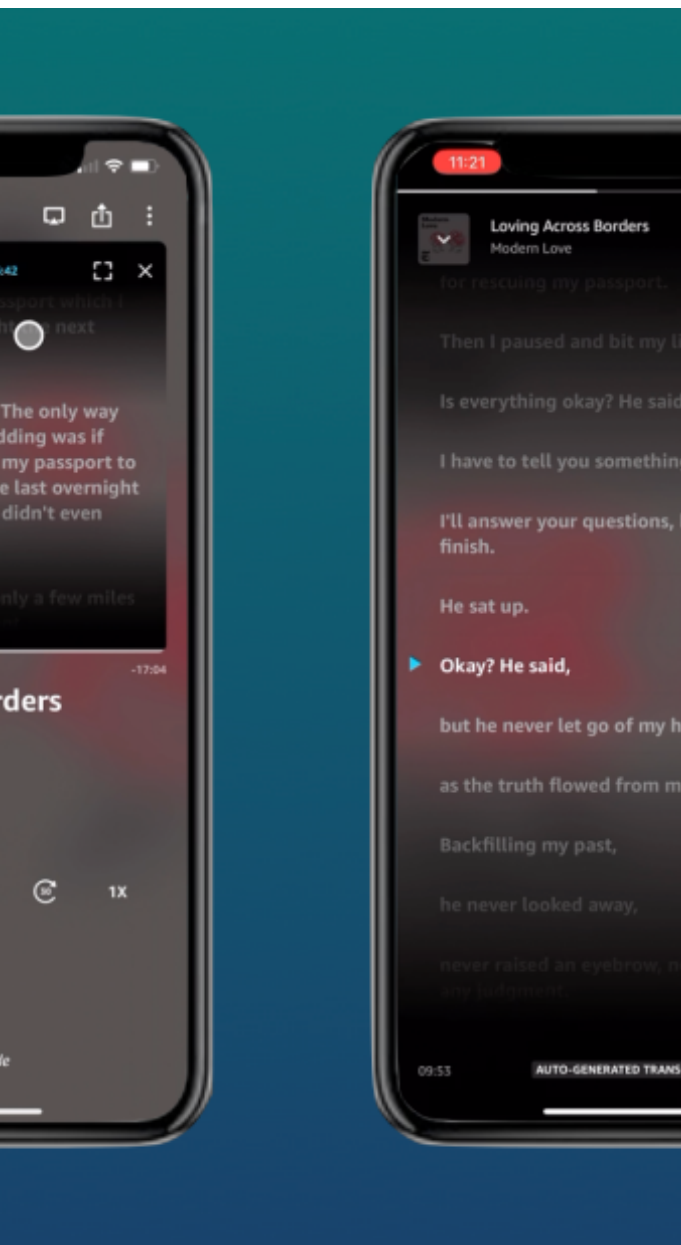


IMAGE CREDITS: AMAZON MUSIC

Amazon Music brings synced transcripts to select podcasts

Amanda Silberling — 8:42 AM PDT · November 2, 2021

Starting today, Amazon Music is launching auto-generated, synchronized transcripts on select podcasts for users in the United States. Rolling out for the latest version of the Amazon Music app on iOS and Android, these transcripts will be available for recent episodes of select podcasts by Amazon Originals and Wondery, a network owned by Amazon. Transcripts will also be available for certain shows from American Public Media,

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audiochuck, Cadence13, The New York Times, Stitcher and TED, like “My Favorite Murder,” “Crime Junkie,” “Modern Love” and “This American Life.”

After [adding podcasts](#) to Amazon Music in September 2020, this is the first major [podcast feature](#) the app has implemented. Spotify beta tested a [similar feature](#) for Spotify Exclusive and Original shows in May. Creators on Apple Podcasts can include transcriptions in their show notes, which are then [searchable](#) in the app, but they aren’t synced with audio in this way.

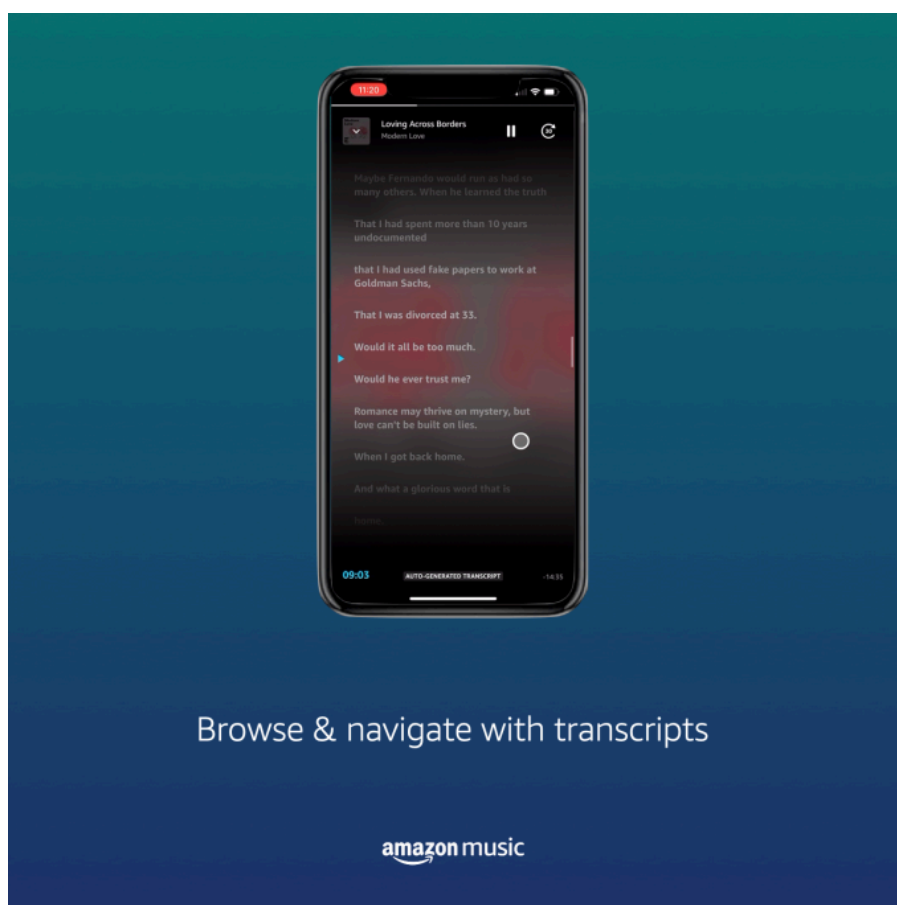


IMAGE CREDITS: AMAZON MUSIC

Listeners can read the transcript in paragraph form in the app, or they can listen along, with the words being highlighted as the host says them. This feature also can be useful for finding a certain place in a podcast if you want to revisit an episode later — while dragging the cursor along, users will be able to see previews of the words being spoken, like scrubbing a video and seeing thumbnail previews.

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As an audio-only medium, transcriptions are essential for podcasters to reach deaf and hard-of-hearing audiences. Many podcasts already post transcriptions on their website, but this feature offers another way to experience a show. When it comes to live audio, live captioning is an essential accessibility feature — while [Twitter Spaces](#) offers this, Clubhouse has yet to implement the feature.

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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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Wondery wants to become Hollywood's podcast dream factory

Jonathan Shieber — 1:24 PM PDT · March 29, 2018

When Hernan Lopez, the former chief executive of Fox International, started the podcast network [Wondery](#) roughly two years ago with a seed investment from his former bosses at Fox Networks Group, podcasting was still emerging as a media platform.

Now, with voice ascendant, and podcasting proving to be a breeding ground for new narratives that

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other storytelling mediums can latch onto — the move into the reinvention of radio for the 21st century seems prescient.

It's not just Fox that is now backing the podcast business; new investors led by storied venture capital and private equity investor Alan Patricof's Greycroft Partners are coming aboard with a \$5 million commitment to expand the scope of Wondery's wonder factory. Additional investors include Lerer Hippeau Ventures and Advancit Capital — the investment vehicle for Shari Redstone (daughter of billionaire media mogul Sumner Redstone).

Previous investors BAM Ventures, Watertower Ventures, Fox Networks Group and BDML also participated in the round.

According to [The Hollywood Reporter](#), Wondery intends to add new shows to its stable, including *American Innovations*, *Dr. Death* and *I, Survivor*, and has optioned *Sword and Scale* and *Tides of History* as projects for movies and television.

While traditional media companies are being forced to join forces and combine assets to protect their market from new competitors like Facebook, Apple, Amazon, Hulu and Netflix coming from the tech industry, new media platforms like podcasting are opening up opportunities for different kinds of studios to emerge.

"I believe there's a huge opportunity in audio," Lopez says. "There isn't anywhere close to enough quality audio content being produced."

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Google denies AI search features are killing website traffic

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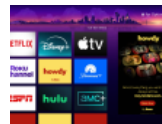
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On average, the modern consumer listens to four hours of audio per day, according to Lopez. Even though most of that is music, an increasing number of Americans are turning to podcasts as a new form

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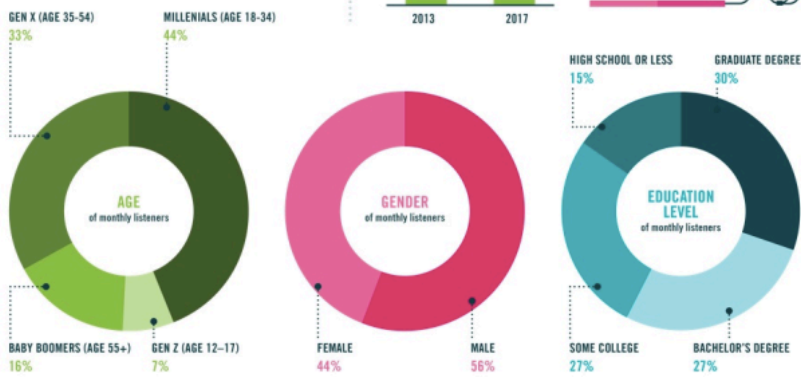
Events
Podcasts
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Demographics are another key reason that advertisers are moving to podcasts, he says, and Comscore research (funded by Wondery) seems to back up his assertions.

WHO'S LISTENING

A whopping 68 million Americans, nearly 1 in 4,* tune in monthly. These regular listeners tend to be educated, Millennial, and male—and the genre is growing fast.



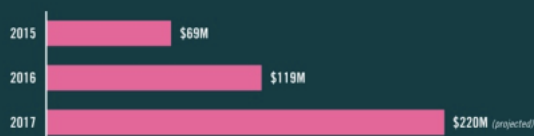
According to Comscore, nearly one in five Americans aged 18-49 said they'd listened to podcasts at least once a month — a number that increases when it's restricted to the highly coveted demographic of men between the ages of 18 and 34, while nearly one in three men 18-34 do so. Podcast listeners are also more likely to have a college degree, make more than \$100,000 and be early adopters of electronics, consumer goods and entertainment.

Advertisers are beginning to take notice, with \$119 million spent on podcast advertising in 2016 and an estimated \$220 million spent on podcast ads last year (according to estimated figures in a survey underwritten by major podcast networks).



LISTENERS AS CUSTOMERS

This burgeoning audience [read: market] isn't lost on advertisers. In the past 2 years, podcasting ad revenue has grown by double digits.*



Some of Wondery's podcasts have already racked up impressive numbers. [Dirty John](#) has been downloaded more than 20 million times; [American History Tellers](#) has been downloaded more than 3

million times; and [Business Wars](#) more than 2 million times, says Lopez.

Wondery is also bucking the media trend of serving up micro-content to audiences.

“We don’t produce much micro-content — if any,” says Lopez. “The stories that we tend to gravitate towards tend to work better in long-form. We have to keep their attention for as long as possible.”

Lopez’s Wondery isn’t the only company to rake in money from institutional investors for building a podcasting empire.

On the other side of the country in the borough of Brooklyn stands Gimlet Media, the \$20 million king of the podcast market these days. Gimlet raised from a slew of investors, including WPP, Betaworks, Stripes Group, Lowercase Capital, LionTree Parters, Emerson Collective, Cross Culture Ventures and music manager turned investor Troy Carter.

Success among podcasts is also translating into options in other formats. As The New York Times noted yesterday, podcasts are getting “[the Hollywood treatment](#).”

Wondery’s own “[Dirty John](#)” is being turned into a series for two networks — true crime stories on Oxygen and as the basis for a scripted series on Bravo. Meanwhile, “Welcome to Night Vale,” “Alice Isn’t Dead,” “Up and Vanished” and “Crimetown” are all being turned into series by different production companies.

“In the last year or so, podcasts have been *the thing*,” Matt Tarses, the creator of “Alex, Inc.” (a new ABC show based off of Gimlet Media’s “Startup” podcast) told The New York Times.

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Amazon acquires podcast network Wondery

Anthony Ha — 10:28 AM PST · December 30, 2020

Amazon just announced that it's [acquiring](#) Wondery, the network behind podcasts including "Dirty John" and "Dr. Death."

Wondery will become part of Amazon Music, which [added support for podcasts](#) (including its own original shows) in September. At the same time, the announcement claims that "nothing will change for listeners" and that the network's podcasts will continue to be available from "a variety of providers."

Media companies and streaming audio platforms are all making big bets on podcasting, with Spotify making a series of acquisitions [including podcast network Gimlet](#), [SiriusXM acquiring Stitcher](#) and [The New York Times acquiring Serial Productions](#). Amazon is coming relatively late to this market, but it will now have the support of a popular podcast maker as it works to catch up.

"With Amazon Music, Wondery will be able to provide even more high-quality, innovative content and continue their mission of bringing a world of

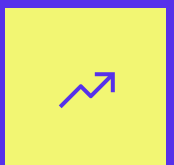
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entertainment and knowledge to their audiences, wherever they listen,” Amazon wrote.

Financial terms were not disclosed. The Wall Street Journal [previously reported](#) that acquisition talks were in the works, and that those talks valued Wondery at around \$300 million.

The startup was [founded in 2016 by former Fox executive Hernan Lopez](#) (who’s [currently fighting federal corruption charges](#) tied to his time at Fox). [Numbers from Podtrac](#) rank it as the fourth largest podcast publisher in November, with an audience in the U.S. of more than 9 million unique listeners.

Wondery has raised a total of \$15 million in funding from Advancit Capital, BDML, Greycroft, Lerer Hippeau and others, [according to Crunchbase](#).

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Amazon Music adds podcasts, including its own original shows



Amazon Music is the latest streaming service to embrace podcasts. The company announced this morning it's launching support for podcasts in the U.S., U.K., Germany and Japan on Amazon Music at no additional cost, and is rolling out its own original programming. The first slate of originals on Amazon Music will include shows hosted by ... Continue reading

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Anthony Ha is TechCrunch’s weekend editor. Previously, he worked as a tech reporter at Adweek, a senior editor at...

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